

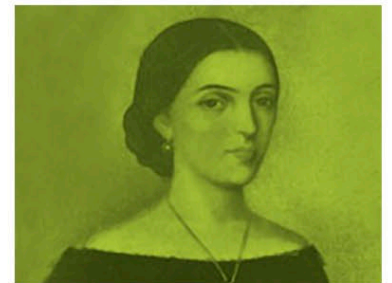
actions wearing the uniform of a cavalryman. Famously, in 1816 she led her forces to capture the Cerro Rico of Potosí, which was the main source of Spanish silver. In 2015, Argentine president Cristina Fernández de Kirchner granted Azurduy a posthumous promotion to the rank of general in recognition of her role in Latin America's struggle for independence.

Indigenous participants

Women also participated in the Wars of Independence as ordinary soldiers. In the 1821 Battle of Carabobo, dozens of women on both sides were killed fighting. In addition to those of Spanish descent, thousands of indigenous women took part in the wars, notably in 1819–1820 in the Peruvian Andes.

Another way in which women became involved in the struggle was by providing meeting places for the rebels. Manuela Cañizares hosted the gathering of the Quito revolutionaries during which they issued the first Proclamation of Independence in 1809. Many female insurgents who organized networks of rebels courageously refused to betray them even under torture.

Although women played a significant role in the struggles that led to the countries of Latin America gaining their independence, “liberty” was not granted to women in the new nations. They continued to be denied political privileges and to fight for their rights, well into the 20th century.



BIOGRAPHY

MANUELA SÁENZ

A young married woman with elite connections in Peru, Manuela Sáenz (1797–1856) defied her husband to join the rebels fighting to liberate Peru from Spain. She became the mistress of Simón Bolívar, credited as the liberator of South America. Sáenz gathered important information, distributed leaflets, organized troops, and rescued the injured. She campaigned for women's rights and was a significant posthumous influence on the 20th-century feminist movement in Latin America.



◀ Tried and convicted

Policarpa Salavarrieta (c. 1795–1817) joined the rebel cause in what is now Colombia. In 1817 she was tried for treason, convicted, and executed by firing squad along with her lover.